GOVERNMENT OF INDIA

# Ministry of Communications

Connecting Every Citizen,
Enabling Every Opportunity

Confidential and Proprietory
August 2026

# SHRI NARENDRA MODI

## HONORABLE PRIME MINISTER, INDIA



## MESSAGE

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# SHRI JYOTIRADITYA M. SCINDIA

## HONORABLE MINISTER, MINISTRY OF COMMUNICATION



## MESSAGE

# SHRI MUNINDRA KUMAR

## DIRECTOR GENERAL, CHAMBER OF COMMERCE AND INDUSTRIES OF INDIA



## MESSAGE

A robust digital communication infrastructure is fundamental to India's economic progress, social inclusion, governance, and technological advancement. The Ministry of Communications has been instrumental in expanding telecommunications, postal services, digital connectivity, broadband access, and next-generation communication technologies that are transforming the lives of millions across urban and rural India.

The Chamber of Commerce and Industries of India (CCI India) recognizes the immense opportunities presented by India's rapidly evolving communications ecosystem. Through policy advocacy, investment promotion, digital innovation, technology partnerships, startup engagement, capacity building, and industry collaboration, CCI India remains committed to supporting the Ministry's efforts in strengthening digital infrastructure and enhancing connectivity across the nation.

This Knowledge Paper presents an extensive overview of the Ministry's strategic priorities, regulatory landscape, infrastructure development initiatives, digital transformation agenda, investment opportunities, and emerging technologies shaping the communications sector. It explores opportunities in 5G deployment, satellite communications, digital infrastructure, postal modernization, cybersecurity, rural connectivity, smart networks, and innovation-driven telecommunications services.

The publication serves as a valuable resource for policymakers, telecom operators, technology companies, startups, investors, academic institutions, research organizations, and development partners seeking to contribute to India's digital growth journey. By encouraging strategic partnerships and collaborative innovation, it aims to support inclusive connectivity, strengthen digital ecosystems, improve service delivery, and accelerate economic development.

As India advances towards becoming a digitally empowered knowledge economy, effective collaboration between government, industry, and technology stakeholders will remain essential. CCI India is committed to working alongside the Ministry of Communications in building a future-ready, secure, and globally competitive communications ecosystem.

Munindra Kumar
Director General
CCI India

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# PREFACE

India's communication sector stands at a historic inflection point. The Ministry of Communication encompassing the Department of Telecommunications (DoT) and the Department of Posts (DoP) governs the foundational infrastructure that connects 1.4 billion citizens, powers the digital economy, and enables India's aspiration to become a globally competitive knowledge economy by 2047. As the architect of policies that determine how India communicates, transacts, innovates, and governs, this Ministry bears a mandate of extraordinary national consequence.

This Knowledge Paper has been prepared by CCI India Chamber of Commerce and Industry of India to serve as a strategic reference document for policymakers, senior government officials, industry leaders, investors, and development institutions engaged with India's communications and digital infrastructure landscape. The paper synthesises Ministry mandates, sector performance data, structural gaps, emerging opportunity clusters, and a forward-looking collaboration framework through an analytical, consulting-grade lens.

The purpose of this document is threefold: first, to provide a rigorous situational assessment of the Ministry's programmatic landscape and the macroeconomic ecosystem it governs; second, to identify strategic gaps where industry partnership can accelerate national outcomes; and third, to articulate a structured framework through which CCI India can serve as a credible, high-impact strategic partner to the Ministry across policy facilitation, investment promotion, innovation enablement, and ecosystem development.

CCI India envisions an India where the communication revolution reaches every citizen from urban metros to the last rural mile and where Indian enterprises, startups, and innovators lead the global conversation on next-generation connectivity, digital public infrastructure, and intelligent communications. This knowledge paper is a contribution toward that vision.

The intended audience for this document includes Union Ministers, Secretaries to the Government of India, NITI Aayog leadership, senior bureaucrats, industry captains, institutional investors, development finance institutions, and international multilateral bodies engaged with India's digital transformation agenda.

**Chamber of Commerce and Industry (CCI India)**

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## About CCI India

CCI India (The Chamber of Commerce and Industry of India) is a premier national business chamber dedicated to fostering economic growth, industry development, entrepreneurship, innovation, and investment promotion across India. As the voice of Indian business and industry, CCI India serves as a bridge between government, industry, startups, academia, investors, and civil society, facilitating meaningful collaboration for nation-building and sustainable development.

Through policy advocacy, business facilitation, research, stakeholder engagement, capacity building, and strategic partnerships, CCI India works to create an enabling environment for enterprises of all sizes. The Chamber actively supports key national initiatives such as Startup India, Make in India, Digital India, Atmanirbhar Bharat, Skill India, and Viksit Bharat 2047 by connecting innovative enterprises with government opportunities and promoting inclusive economic development.

CCI India operates through sector-specific councils, industry forums, knowledge platforms, and state-level engagements that address emerging opportunities and challenges across sectors including manufacturing, agriculture, technology, healthcare, education, infrastructure, sustainability, MSMEs, and startups. The Chamber regularly organizes policy dialogues, investment summits, business delegations, workshops, conferences, and knowledge-sharing initiatives to strengthen India's economic ecosystem.

With a strong commitment to innovation, entrepreneurship, and public-private collaboration, CCI India strives to empower enterprises, facilitate investment, enhance competitiveness, and contribute to India's journey toward becoming a globally competitive and economically resilient nation. Its role as a knowledge partner and industry catalyst enables ministries, departments, state governments, startups, and businesses to collaborate effectively in achieving national development objectives.

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# SECTION 1: Introduction to the Ministry of Communication

## 1.1 Constitutional and Institutional Mandate

The Ministry of Communication derives its constitutional authority from Entry 31 of the Union List (Seventh Schedule, Article 246 of the Constitution of India), which vests exclusive legislative power over posts and telegraphs, including telephones, wireless, broadcasting, and other similar forms of communication in the Union Government. This constitutional monopoly reflects the founding recognition that communication infrastructure is an instrument of national integration, sovereignty, and security a recognition that has only deepened as digital communications emerged as the backbone of modern statehood and economic competitiveness.

Institutionally, the Ministry operates through two principal departments: the Department of Telecommunications (DoT), which governs spectrum management, licensing, telecom policy, universal service obligations, and satellite communications; and the Department of Posts (DoP), which administers India's postal network, postal financial services, and e-commerce logistics. Together, these departments regulate, develop, and promote one of the world's most complex and consequential communication ecosystems.

## 1.2 Governance Role and National Significance

The Ministry's governance function extends well beyond service provision. It is the architect of the Indian telecom regulatory framework, determining licensing conditions for telecom operators, allocating scarce spectrum resources, setting quality-of-service standards, and adjudicating between competing commercial and public interest imperatives. Through the Telecom Regulatory Authority of India (TRAI) and the Telecom Disputes Settlement and Appellate Tribunal (TDSAT), the Ministry oversees a quasi-judicial governance architecture that balances investor interests with consumer protection and public policy objectives.

The Ministry's national significance is measurable across multiple dimensions. Its telecom infrastructure underpins India's USD 3.7 trillion economy every digital payment, cloud transaction, e-commerce order, telemedicine consultation, and online education session traverses networks regulated by DoT. Its postal network serves as the nation's most extensive physical distribution infrastructure, reaching villages, tribal hamlets, and remote islands where no other institutional presence exists. In this dual role digital backbone and last-mile physical reach the Ministry of Communication occupies a position of unparalleled strategic importance in India's national development architecture.

# SECTION 2: Historical Timeline of the Ministry

## 2.1 Institutional Evolution and Policy Transformation

The Ministry of Communication has undergone a century-long institutional metamorphosis from a colonial-era postal and telegraph department into a sophisticated regulator and promoter of 21st-century digital infrastructure. Understanding this evolution is essential to contextualise current policy priorities and appreciate the structural path-dependencies that shape ministerial decision-making today.

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| Year / Era | Key Milestone / Reform | Strategic Significance |
|---|---|---|
| **1854** | Establishment of the Department of Posts and Telegraphs under British India | Foundation of India's centralised communication administration; telegraph became an instrument of colonial control and national connectivity. |
| **1947** | Post-Independence restructuring; DoP separated from DoT | Nationalisation of communications as a sovereign function; postal network integrated into nation-building agenda. |
| **1985** | Department of Telecom (DoT) formally constituted; VSNL established | Institutional recognition of telecom as a distinct strategic domain; foundation for future liberalisation. |
| **1994** | National Telecom Policy 1994; private sector entry into basic telecom services | Historic liberalisation; dismantling of DoT's monopoly and creation of a competitive market framework. |
| **1997** | Establishment of TRAI (Telecom Regulatory Authority of India) | India's first independent sector regulator; critical institutional innovation separating policy from regulation. |
| **1999** | New Telecom Policy (NTP 1999); migration to revenue-sharing regime | Migration from fixed licence fees to revenue-sharing fundamentally altered operator economics and spurred rapid subscriber growth. |
| **2002–04** | VSNL disinvestment; BSNL corporatisation; unified access service regime | Market-oriented structural transformation; entry of private operators in long-distance and international segments. |
| **2012** | Supreme Court cancellation of 122 telecom licences; spectrum auction reforms | Landmark governance moment; transition to transparent market-based spectrum allocation. |
| **2016** | BharatNet Phase I launch; Digital India Mission; Jio entry triggers data revolution | Convergence of infrastructure investment and market disruption; India's data consumption explosion commenced. |
| **2021–22** | Telecom Reforms Package; AGR relief; DoT spectrum liberalisation | Financial stabilisation of the telecom sector; prevented market consolidation to duopoly. |
| **2022** | 5G Spectrum Auction India's largest; 5G services launched by Jio and Airtel | India leapfrogged into next-generation connectivity; auction realised Rs. 1.5 lakh crore. |
| **2023** | Telecom Act 2023 replaces Indian Telegraph Act 1885; major legislative modernisation | Most consequential telecom legislation in 138 years; comprehensive framework for 5G, satellite, cybersecurity, and spectrum governance. |

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